

JULY 24, 2026 · PHILADELPHIA

# The Biggest Heist in NBA Free Agency History

What LeBron James to the 76ers actually means — rebuilt from source data, every number re-derived.

*A data-verified recreation of the viral breakdown by TikTok's @leah.cammarano. Her structure and thesis; independent stats, models, and projections throughout.*

## THE DEAL

# A four-MVP resume at 2.35% of the salary cap

**2 yrs · \$8M**

player option on 2027-28  
(\$4.07M)

**\$3,876,529**

2026-27 cap hit — the 10+ yr  
veteran minimum

**-92%**

pay cut from his \$52.6M  
Lakers salary, the largest in  
NBA history

**2.35%**

of the \$164.96M cap for the  
all-time scoring leader  
(43,440 pts)

*“This is my last decision. I’m not going for money. I’m not going for family... I still want to compete, to win and to have a chance at the feeling of winning another championship.”*

— LeBron James, announcing on X, entering season 24 at age 41 (42 on Dec 30)

### The new starting five

**Maxey · Edgecombe · Brown · James · Embiid**

36 All-Star selections and 5 MVP awards combined.  
Brown arrived July 2 from Boston for Paul George and four picks; LeBron arrived for the minimum.

## WHY PHILADELPHIA

# The one fatal flaw — nobody creates easy shots — is the thing he fixes

The 2025-26 Sixers won 45 games while being outscored (SRS -0.27) — a 7-seed that survived on Maxey's solo shot-making and lost the moment the playoffs demanded easy offense (swept 4-0 by the champion Knicks).

### LeBron is the most decorated table-setter alive:

9 of 10 seasons from 2008-09 to 2017-18 his offenses finished top-5 as he ran them solo. In 2025-26, 42.1% of his assists produced rim shots and 11.8% corner threes — the two most efficient shots in basketball. His 162 corner-3 assists in 2016-17 remain the most ever recorded.

**55.3%**

of Maxey's 694 makes were unassisted — league mean is 36.3%

**34.9%**

of Embiid's makes came at the rim — an MVP big living on jumpers

**36.4%**

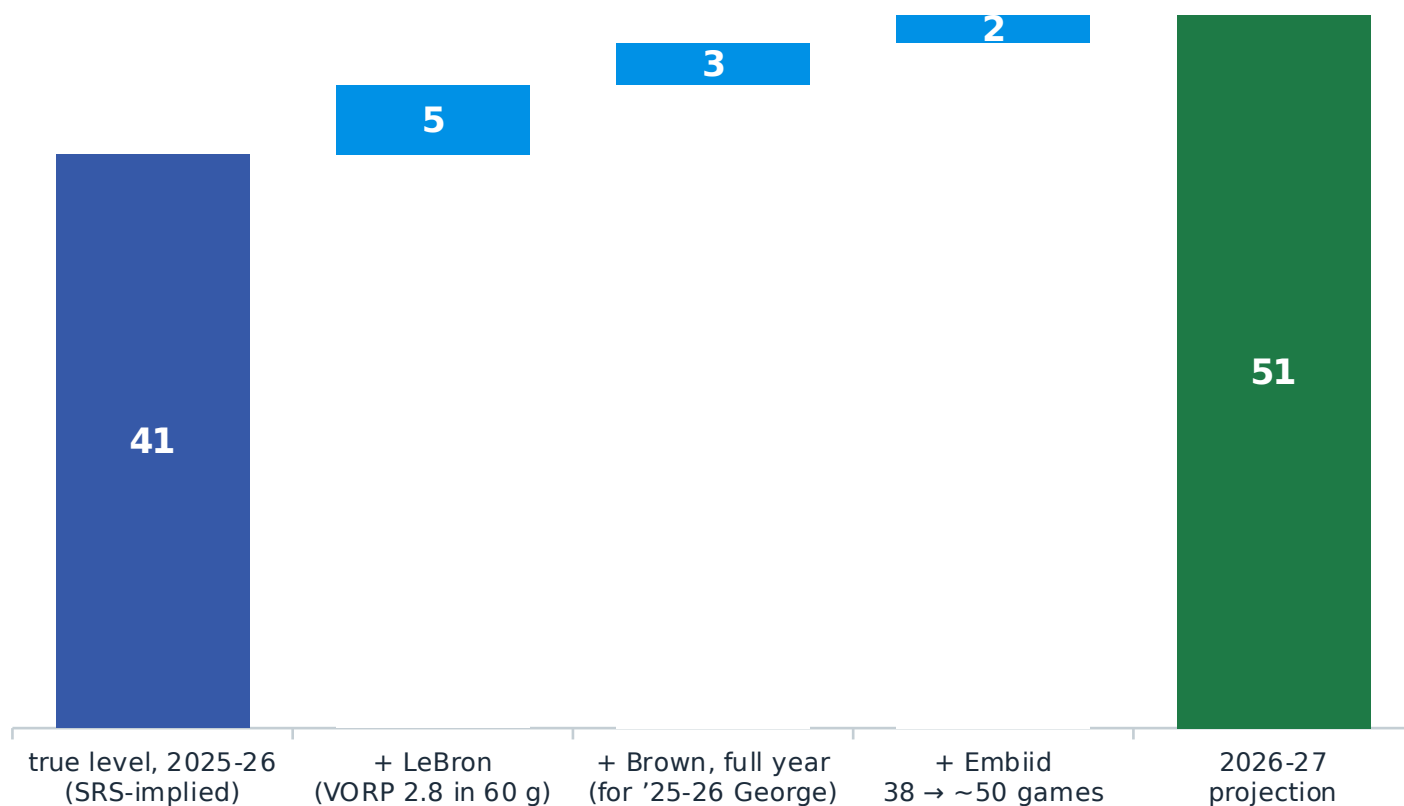
of Brown's makes were assisted carrying Boston — down from 47.6%

**5.5%**

of rookie Edgecombe's makes were corner 3s — the skip pass never came

## TEAM LEVEL

# 45 wins was a mirage; 51 is the honest projection



### The ledger

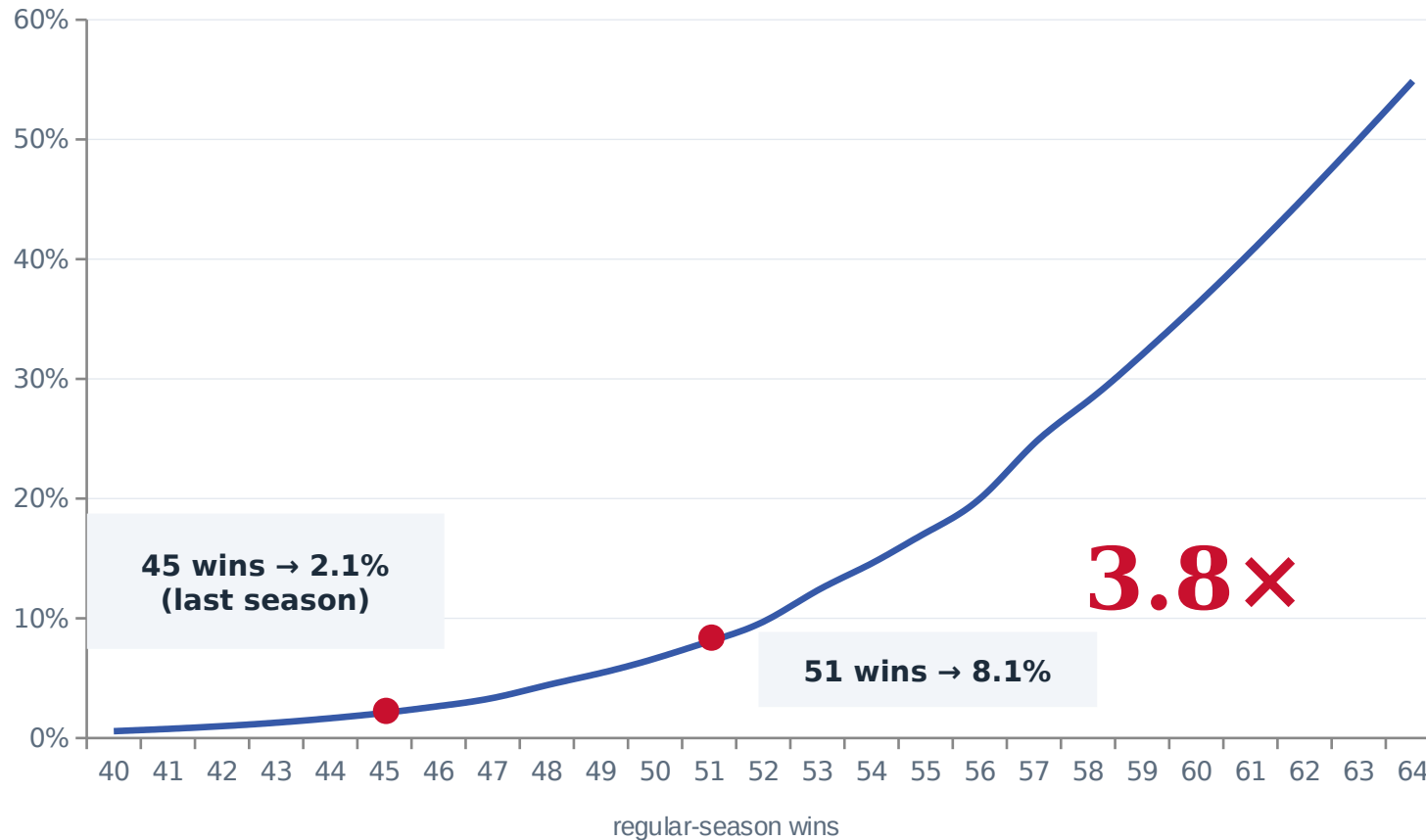
45-37 overstated the 2025-26 team: its  $-0.27$  point differential is 41-win talent. LeBron's 2025-26 value (B-Ref VORP 2.8 in 60 games  $\approx 7.6$  wins over replacement) nets  $\sim +5$  over the minutes he displaces; a full year of Jaylen Brown replacing 36-year-old Paul George nets  $\sim +3$ ; Embiid reaching  $\sim 50$  games adds  $\sim +2$ .

### The market agrees

FanDuel set the post-signing win total at 50.5. Title odds moved  $+2000 \rightarrow +900$  (DraftKings) within hours. The video projected 51 — same answer, three routes.

THE CURVE THAT MAKES IT A HEIST

# Finals probability is logistic — six wins land on the steep part



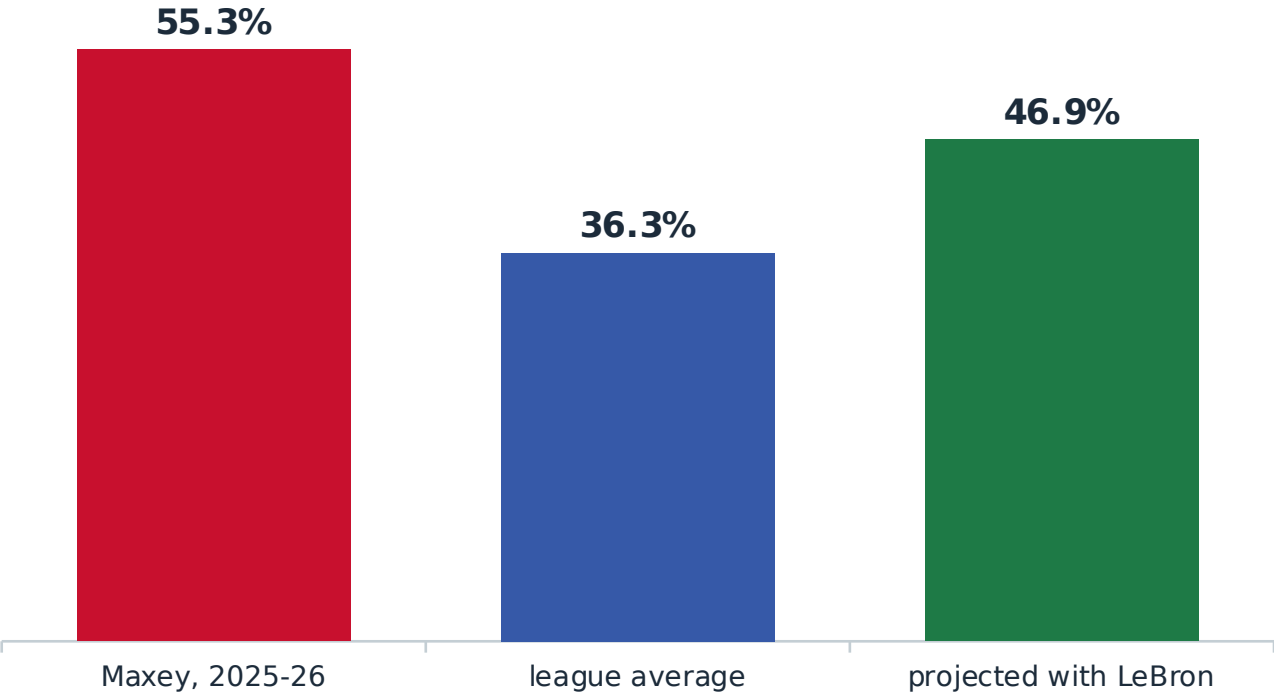
**My model:** Log5 game odds + home court, exact best-of-7, three rounds vs a 48/53/57-win gauntlet. 45 wins → 2.1%; 51 → 8.1%; 52 → 9.7% (4.6x). The video said 4% → 12%, “3.2x” — same shape, softer baseline.

**History is harsher:** since 1984, 44-47-win teams took 2 of 78 full-season Finals berths (2.6%) — and no 7-seed has ever made the Finals. The median finalist won 58. 50+ wins covered 96% of all berths.

**Same conclusion, stronger:** the six wins LeBron adds sit exactly where the curve bends.

# Maxey — five years of doing it alone

Unassisted share of made field goals, 2025-26 (694 FGM)



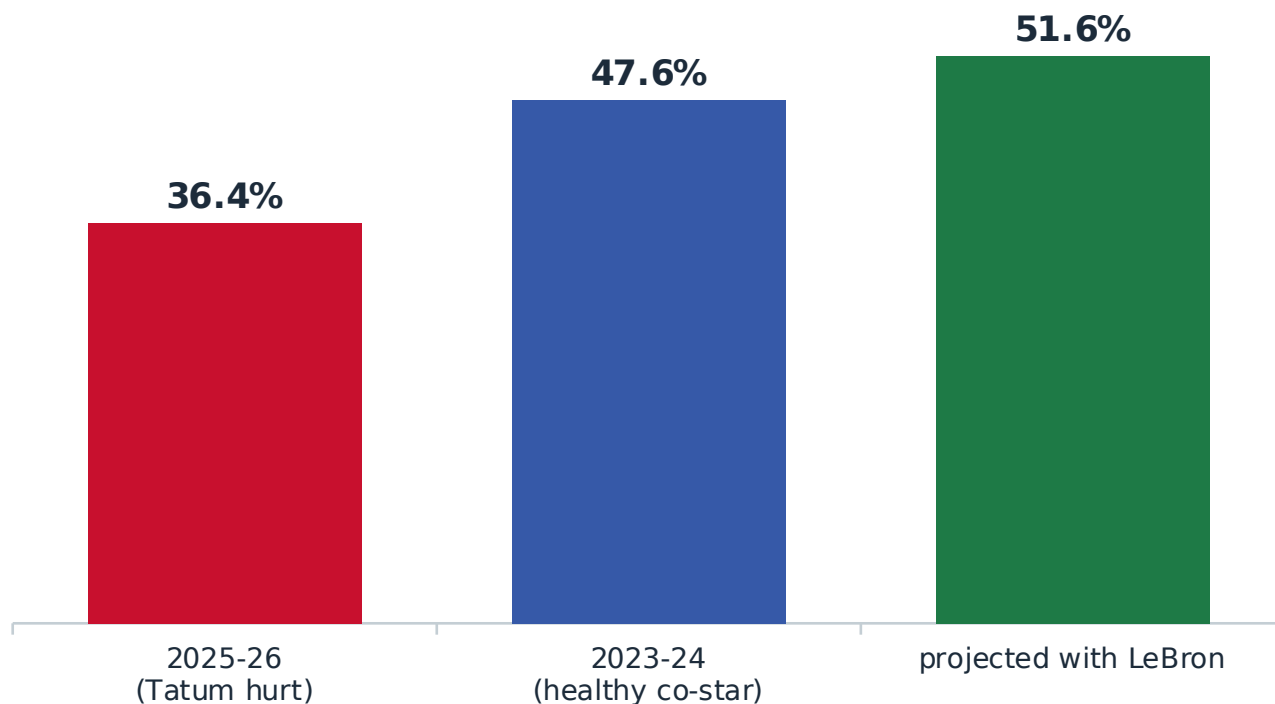
55.3% of Maxey’s baskets were self-created — 19 points above the league mean. He led the team at 28.3 ppg on 70 games of isolation offense.

**The projection:** guards who joined LeBron saw their assisted share rise +8.4 pts on average (Mo Williams +12.6, D’Angelo Russell +11.1, Kyrie +1.5 — and Kyrie’s 3P assisted share jumped 45.5→61.8%). Applied to Maxey: unassisted falls to ~47% (video said 45%).

*For the first time in his career, he gets to run to a spot and shoot.*

# Brown — a Finals MVP getting easy ones again

Assisted share of made field goals (736 FGM in 2025-26)



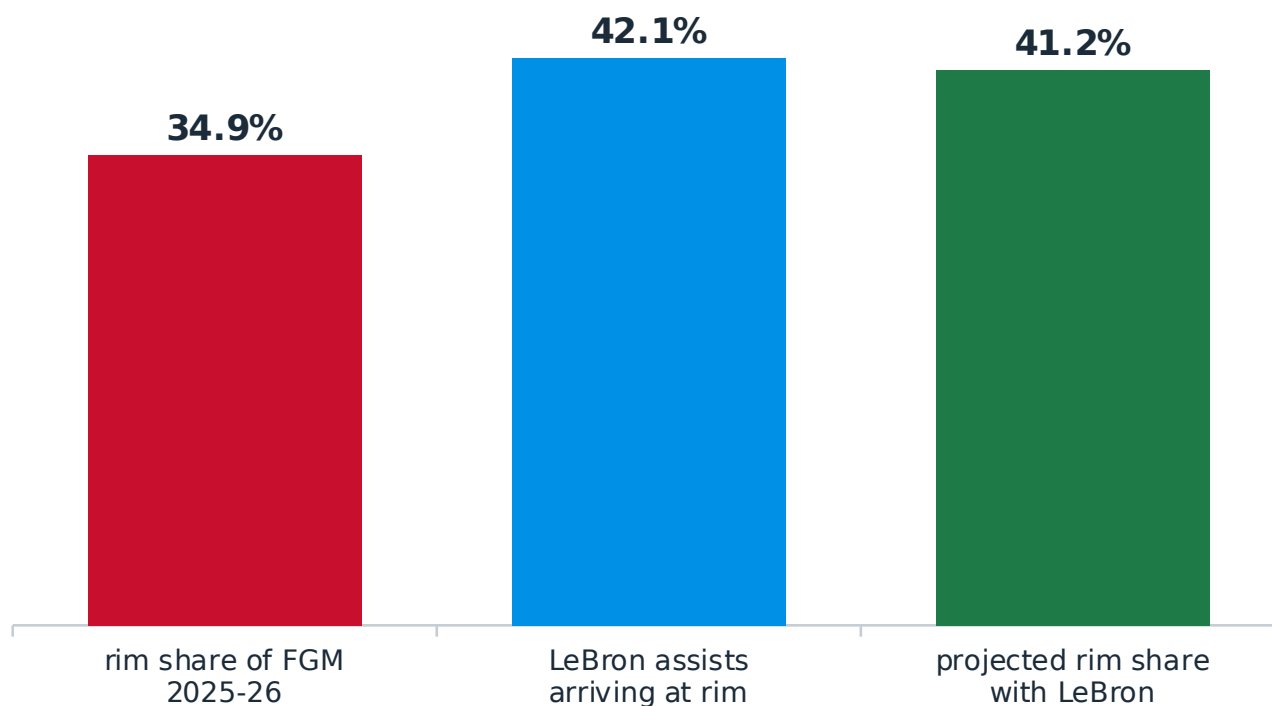
Carrying Boston at a career-high 36.2% usage, Brown's assisted share collapsed to 36.4%. With a healthy star beside him in 2023-24 it was 47.6%.

**The projection:** restore the healthy-co-star baseline, then add half the average LeBron-arrival premium (+4.0): ~52% assisted (video said 48%). LeBron delivers the ball early in the clock, not with three seconds left.

*The easiest shot diet of his career, at age 30.*

# Embiid — an MVP big fed where he wants it

At-rim share of made field goals (341 FGM in 38 games)



Only 34.9% of Embiid's makes came at the rim — a skilled giant surviving on fadeaways because nobody could get him the ball where he wanted it.

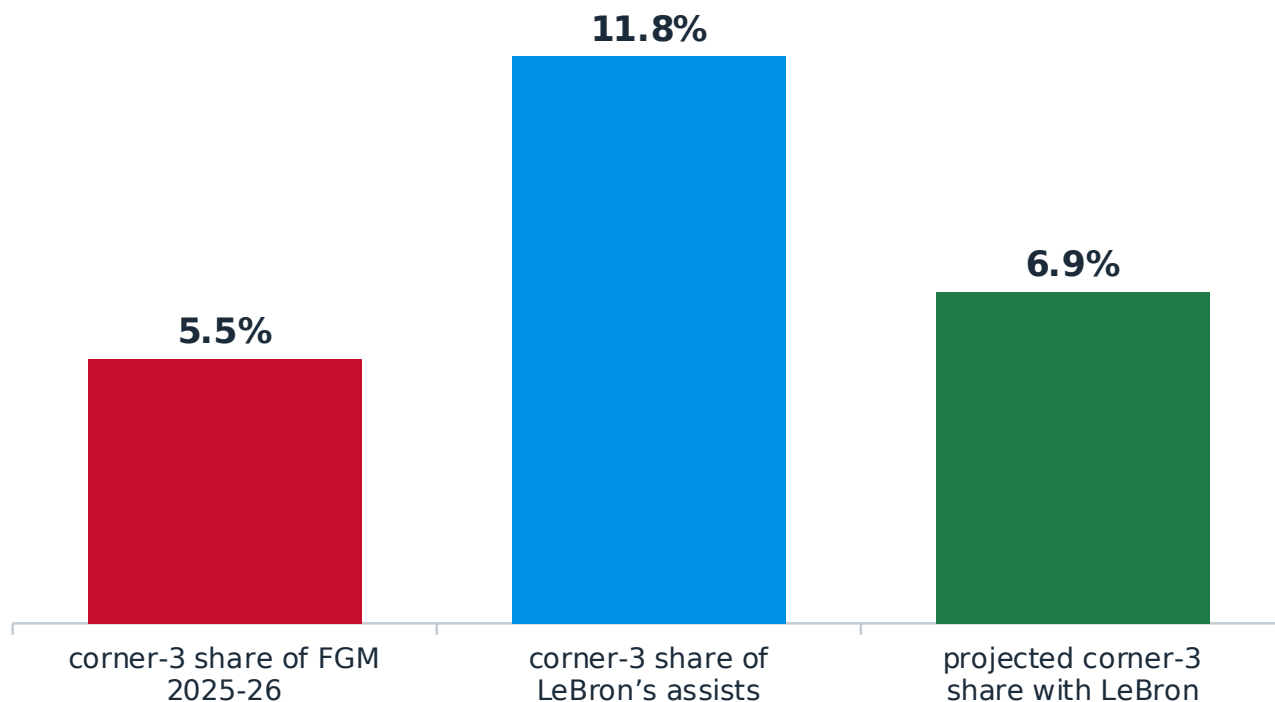
**The projection:** 42.1% of LeBron's 432 assists arrived at the rim (46.6% the year before) — the pocket pass, the lob, the entry nobody else sees. If LeBron assists ~25% of Embiid's makes at a big-man rim rate (~60%), Embiid's rim share climbs to ~41% (range 39-44).

*The video said 37% → 42% off "52% of 765 assists" — the right idea with the wrong inputs: it's 34.9%, and 42.1% of 432.*



# Edgecombe — the skip pass finally comes

Corner-3 share of made field goals (451 FGM as a rookie)



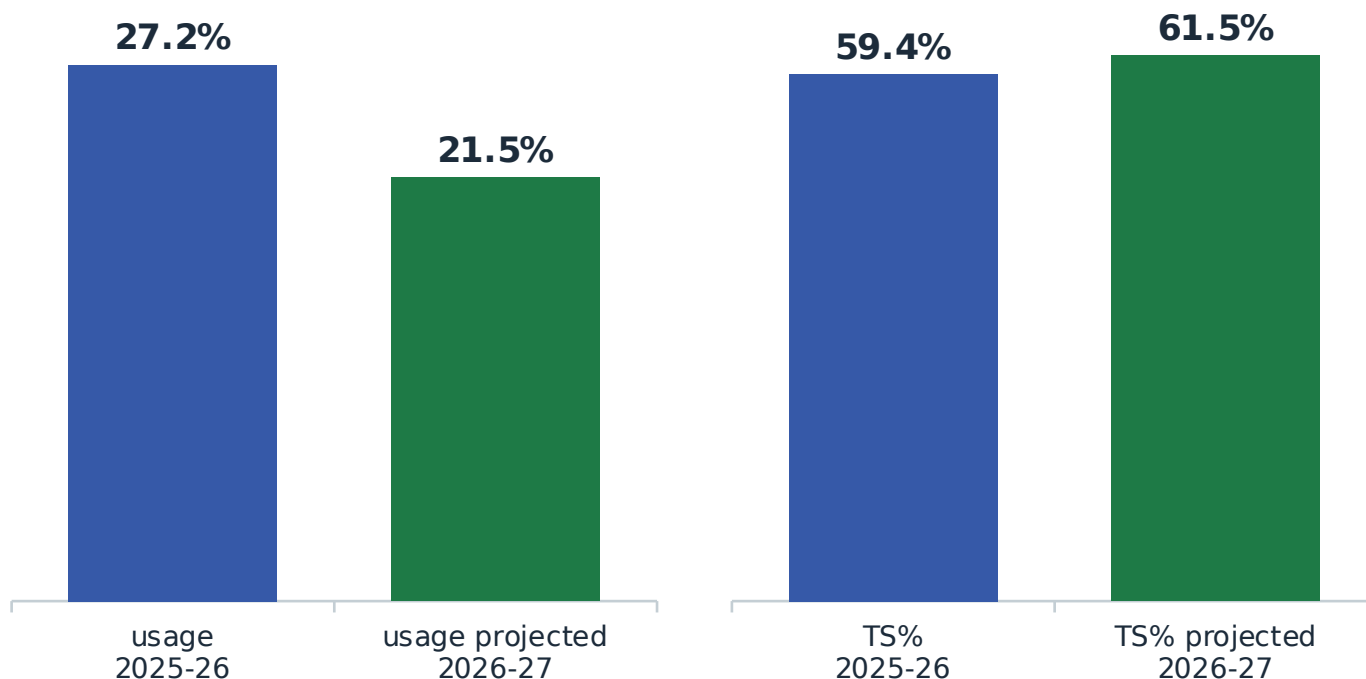
25 of Edgecombe's 451 makes (5.5%) were corner threes — even though 81% of his 3-point makes were assisted. The cross-court skip simply never came from this roster.

**The projection:** LeBron throws the skip better than anyone alive — 11.8% of his assists were corner 3s, and his 162 corner-3 assists in 2016-17 are the most ever recorded. If LeBron assists ~22% of Edgecombe's makes: ~7% (range 6.5-7.4).

*Honest note: the video's 8% → 12% doesn't match the shot data (5.5% baseline, 25 makes). The free points are real; the magnitude is smaller.*

# LeBron — fewer possessions, the perfect ones

Usage rate and true shooting, 2025-26 measured → 2026-27 projected



**Usage:** 27.2% was already a career low (his rookie floor was 28.2%). Stars who joined LeBron shed 5-7 usage points (Bosh 28.5→23.4, Love 28.7→21.6). Now he's the one joining three stars: ~21-22%, the fewest possessions of his life.

**Efficiency:** the skill-curve tradeoff (+0.3-0.6 TS pts per usage point shed, minus an age-42 drag) projects .594 → .60-.63. The video's .627 is the optimistic edge of that band; his career best is .649 (2013-14).

*At 42, in a Sixers jersey, plausibly the most efficient season of his life.*

THE HEIST, QUANTIFIED

# 18 cents on the dollar

\$21.9M

modeled market value of his 2026-27 production (Sporting News salary model via CBS; \$28.2M for 2025-26)

\$3.88M

what Philadelphia pays. Surplus  $\approx$  \$18M — about 5 wins of talent, free

3.8×

the Finals-odds multiplier those six extra wins buy on the logistic curve

207×

StubHub demand spike within hours; debut get-in \$107 → \$540; jerseys gone in ~2 hours

*Cross-check: ~5 wins added  $\times$  ~\$3.9M market price per win  $\approx$  \$20M. Three methods, one answer: the Sixers acquired a top-25 player for the price of a 12th man.*

# Her numbers vs. the verified data

| Claim in video                          | Video           | Verified / my calc                | Verdict |
|-----------------------------------------|-----------------|-----------------------------------|---------|
| Sixers 2025-26 wins → projection        | 45 → 51         | 45 → 51 (ledger) · mkt 50.5       | exact   |
| Maxey unassisted share (n=694) / league | 55% / 36%       | 55.3% / 36.3%                     | exact   |
| Maxey projected with LeBron             | 45%             | 46.9% (range 43-54)               | close   |
| Brown assisted, 2025-26 / 2023-24       | 36% / 46%       | 36.4% / 47.6%                     | close   |
| Brown projected with LeBron             | 48%             | 51.6%                             | close   |
| LeBron usage / TS, 2025-26              | 27.2% / .594    | 27.2% / .594                      | exact   |
| Embiid rim share of makes               | 37%             | 34.9% (pbpstats)                  | off ~2  |
| “52% of LeBron’s 765 assists at rim”    | 52% · 765       | 42.1% · 432 assists               | wrong   |
| Embiid projected rim share              | 42%             | 41.2% (range 39-44)               | close   |
| Edgecombe corner-3 share → projection   | 8% → 12%        | 5.5% → 6.9%                       | wrong   |
| LeBron projected usage / TS             | 22% / .627      | 21.5% / .60-.63                   | edge    |
| Finals odds: 45w → 51w                  | 4% → 12% (3.2×) | 2.1% → 8.1% (3.8×); empirics 2.6% | shape ✓ |

# Every number, re-derived

## Data

Shot profiles & assist locations: pbpstats.com play-by-play API, cross-checked against Basketball-Reference splits (agreement to the decimal) and StatMuse.

Standings, SRS, advanced value: Basketball-Reference 2025-26.

Contract & cap: NBA.com, ESPN/Klutch, CBS Sports.  
Market: FanDuel/DraftKings via NBC & Liberty Ballers; StubHub/SeatGeek via 6abc.

## Models (in this repo)

Finals curve: Log5 game probabilities, home-court odds  $\times 1.21$ , exact best-of-7 enumeration, three rounds vs a 48/53/57 gauntlet (model.py).

Win ledger: SRS-implied baseline + VORP-based wins added (final\_calcs.py).

Teammate projections: first-season-with-LeBron deltas measured for 6 stars, 2000-2026 (projections.py).

## Honesty box

Projections carry ranges, not certainties; central values shown.

Where the video's inputs failed verification (Edgecombe 8%, '765 assists'), the verified numbers are used and flagged on the slide.

Embiid availability (38 games) is the single biggest swing factor no model fixes.